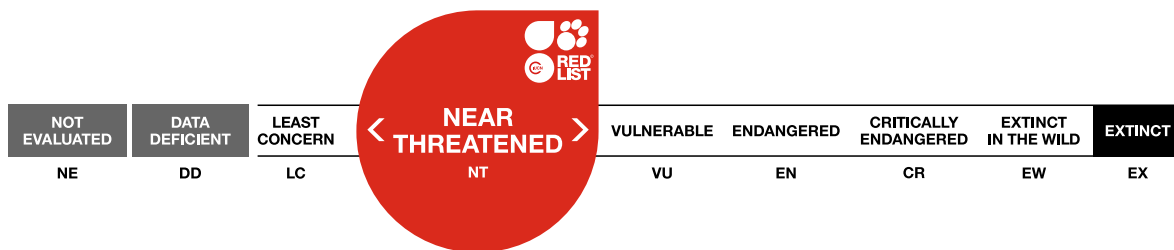


Oroanassa magnifica, White-eared Night Heron

Assessment by: BirdLife International



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Taxonomy

Kingdom	Phylum	Class	Order	Family
Animalia	Chordata	Aves	Pelecaniformes	Ardeidae

Scientific Name: *Oroanassa magnifica* (Ogilvie Grant, 1899)

Synonym(s):

- *Gorsachius magnificus* (Ogilvie Grant, 1899)
- *Nycticorax magnificus* Ogilvie-Grant, 1899

Common Name(s):

- English: White-eared Night Heron, White-eared Night-Heron, White-eared Night-heron

Taxonomic Source(s):

Handbook of the Birds of the World and BirdLife International. 2020. Handbook of the Birds of the World and BirdLife International digital checklist of the birds of the world. Version 5. Available at: http://datazone.birdlife.org/userfiles/file/Species/Taxonomy/HBW-BirdLife_Checklist_v5_Dec20.zip.

Taxonomic Notes:

Oroanassa magnifica (Handbook of the Birds of the World and BirdLife International 2020) was previously listed as *Gorsachius magnificus* (del Hoyo *et al.* 2014).

Analysis of the *Gorsachius* genome reveals that White-eared Night-heron *G. magnificus* (del Hoyo *et al.* 2014) is more closely related to egrets *Egretta* than to *Gorsachius* and *Nycticorax* night-herons, and hence appears to need the resuscitation of the genus *Oroanassa* to be appropriately accommodated in the ardeid phylogeny (Zhou *et al.* 2016).

The morphological differences between *G. magnificus* and the two other members of the genus, *G. goisagi* and *G. melanolophus*, are so striking (length and shape of bill, pattern of head and neck, thickness of neck-plumage, pattern on belly, size of toes) that their congeneric status appears entirely improbable. The revival of *Oroanassa* is therefore accepted by BirdLife, albeit with the proviso that we have undertaken no research to check if the genus *Oroanassa* (Peters, 1931) takes precedence over any other genus name proposed in the past, noting that the species seems fairly similar to the South American *Calherodius* (Bonaparte, 1855) meaning that, if found also to be genetically fairly close, it would qualify instead to be treated as *Calherodius magnificus*.

Identification Information:

54-56 cm. Secretive, boldly patterned night-heron. Males have blackish head and nape plumes, white postocular stripe, cheek-stripe and throat, broad blackish line down neck side, brown underparts with whitish streaks/scales and orange-buff to rufous-chestnut rear neck sides. Females have less distinct head and neck pattern, whitish streaks and spots on back and wings (particularly wing-coverts) and shorter nape plumes. Juvenile resembles female, but dark parts of plumage browner, has heavier whitish to buff spots above.

Assessment Information

Red List Category & Criteria: Near Threatened C2a(ii) [ver 3.1](#)

Year Published: 2025

Date Assessed: May 12, 2025

Justification:

This cryptic species has, in recent years, become much better known. It is now known to have a wide distribution occurring across a large area of south-east China and narrowly in neighbouring countries; its range may yet prove even greater than is currently known. Nonetheless, it appears to be scarce, and is suspected to have a small to moderately small population size of 1,500-15,000 mature individuals. Declines are precautionarily suspected in response to habitat loss. Because this species approaches the thresholds for listing as threatened, it is evaluated as globally Near Threatened.

Previously Published Red List Assessments

[2017 – Endangered \(EN\)](#)

[2016 – Endangered \(EN\)](#)

[2013 – Endangered \(EN\)](#)

2012 – Endangered (EN)

2010 – Endangered (EN)

2008 – Endangered (EN)

2006 – Endangered (EN)

2004 – Endangered (EN)

2000 – Endangered (EN)

1996 – Critically Endangered (CR)

1994 – Critically Endangered (CR)

1988 – Threatened (T)

Geographic Range

Range Description:

Breeding has been recorded in **China** and north **Viet Nam** (BirdLife International 2001, Gao Yuren 2003, He Fenqi and Lin Jiansheng 2004, He Fenqi *et al.* 2007a,b, M. Crosby *in litt.* 2009, 2016, He Fenqi *et al.* 2011, He Fenqi and Jiang 2013, Gao *et al.* 2013). In 2001, the species was known from only c. 20 localities (BirdLife International 2001), but more recent effort has revealed to be quite widespread in China south of the 0°C isotherm (He Fen-qí *in litt.* 2025; also see Figure 1: Ru Jia *et al.* 2023), including exceptionally in Inner Mongolia. Some populations in China are assumed to be resident, as is the population in northern **Viet Nam**, however recent tracking data indicate that at least some birds migrate within China (Ru Jia *et al.* 2023) and presumably beyond its borders (see below). Its status on Hainan, the type locality, is unclear, but it has not been recorded there since 1962.

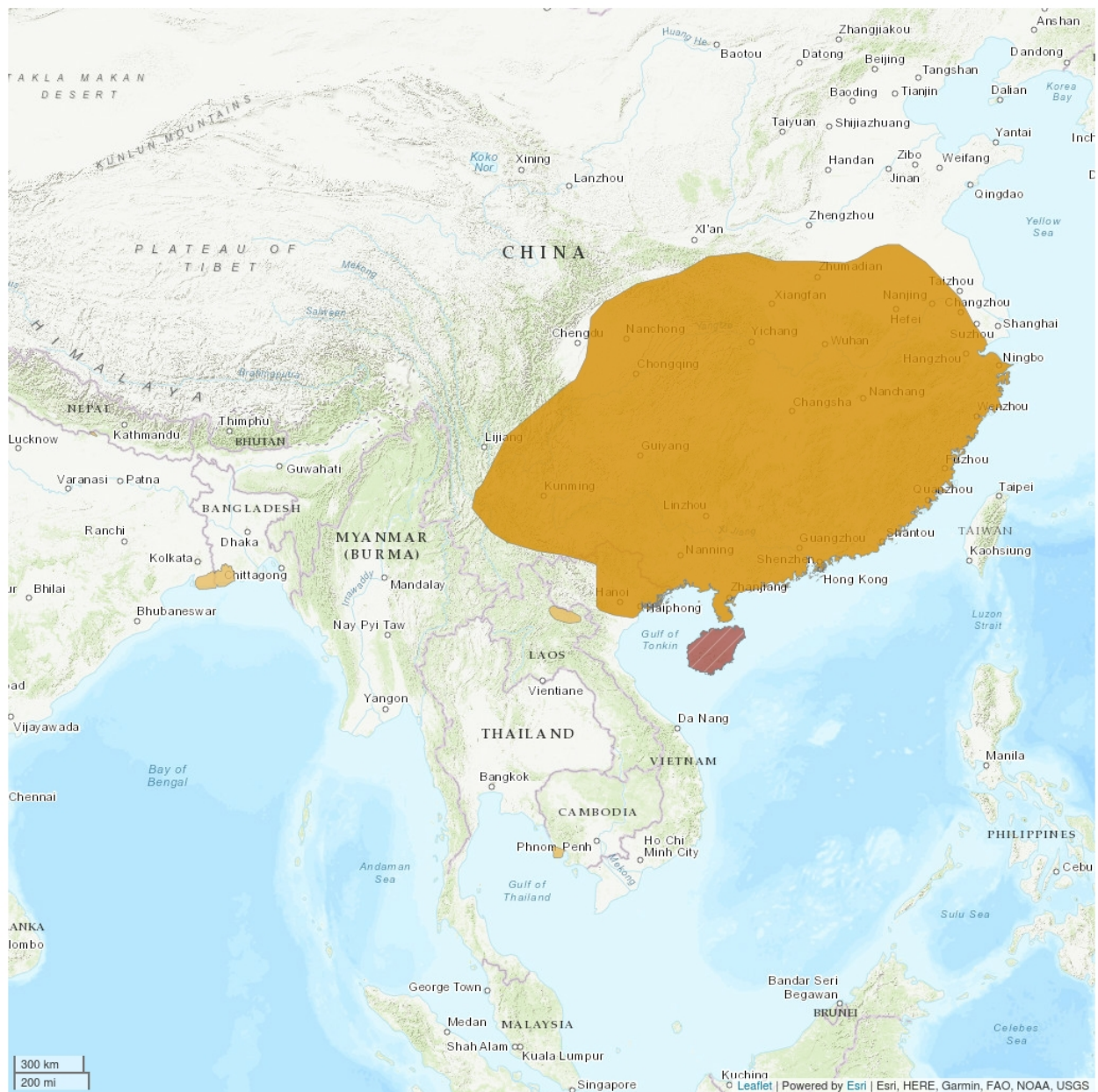
Outside of China and Viet Nam (and even within it) the species' distribution is very poorly known, but the recent pattern of records suggest it is considerably more widespread than previously suspected, at the very least in the non-breeding season. In 2016, a possibly immature bird was photographed on a camera trip in the Valmiki Tiger Reserve, Bihar, **India** (Shafi *et al.* 2018). In March 2017, a bird was photographed in south-west **Cambodia** (Gray *et al.* 2019). The timing of these two records (and the habitat they were recorded in) led both sets of authors to speculate that White-eared Night Heron might plausibly breed at these two localities, and this is certainly possible; in the absence of breeding evidence, however, for now they are mapped here as non-breeding visitors. These discoveries were followed in quick succession by the photographing of a bird in Nam-Et Phou Louey National Park, in October 2023, in north-east **Lao PDR** (S. Chuekongya *in litt.*, in Timmins *et al.* 2024) where again there is suitable breeding habitat and the species may yet prove resident. At least two individuals (but, based on the area of suitable habitat, presumably considerably more) have also been found regularly wintering in the **Bangladesh** Sundarbans (Sadi *et al.* 2023, eBird 2025); given the contiguity of habitat, they can reasonably be assumed also to be wintering in the adjacent Indian Sundarbans. As noted by Timmins *et al.* (2024), it is very likely that this species has historically been overlooked (it is notable that both the India and Cambodia records are from camera traps), and it is possible that further effort will reveal it to be widespread - either as a breeding resident or non-breeding visitor - across much of South-East Asia.

Country Occurrence:

Native, Extant (resident): China; Viet Nam

Native, Extant (non-breeding): Bangladesh; Cambodia; India; Lao People's Democratic Republic

Distribution Map

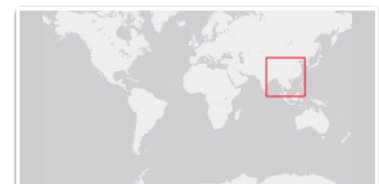


Legend

- EXTANT (RESIDENT)
- EXTANT (NON-BREEDING)
- ▨ POSSIBLY EXTINCT

Compiled by:

BirdLife International and Handbook of the Birds of the World 2025



The boundaries and names shown and the designations used on this map do not imply any official endorsement, acceptance or opinion by IUCN.



Population

The population size of this cryptic species was formerly estimated to number fewer than 1,000 mature individuals (BirdLife International 2001, Brazil 2009), albeit with low certainty due to an absence of records and very imperfect knowledge of its distribution. Following a considerable increase in awareness and survey efforts, the number of observations over the past 25 years has greatly exceeded the number in the 100 years preceding it (eBird 2025, He Fen-qi *in litt.* 2025), such that it is now very difficult to conclude there may be fewer than 1,000 mature individuals. This is made particularly apparent following the ecological niche modelling performed by Junhua Hu and Yang Liu (2014), who identified c. 130,000 km² of potentially suitable habitat; even if only a very small fraction of this is occupied, it is almost certain that the number of actual colonies is considerably greater than the number that have so far been identified. Nonetheless, some degree of caution is necessary, and the global population is here suspected to number 1,500-15,000 mature individuals, capturing a wide range of plausible scenarios.

Trend Justification

The population trend of this species is precautionarily suspected to be declining owing to localised forest cover loss and perhaps hunting (D. L. Yong *in litt.* 2025). However, recent reforestation efforts in China (Hua *et al.* 2016, Global Forest Watch 2025), coupled with the species' apparent tolerance of some habitat modification (it has been documented successfully breeding in artificial forests: Aiwu Jiang *et al.* 2017), suggests that declines are relatively slow.

Current Population Trend: Decreasing

Habitat and Ecology (see Appendix for additional information)

Its ecology remains poorly known but knowledge of it has increased in recent years. It occurs in subtropical and tropical forest, with recent records from sites close to streams, rivers, reservoirs and rice-fields (close to or within forest); in China, one colony was recorded successfully breeding in artificially planted pine forest (Aiwu Jiang *et al.* 2017). Recent records from the non-breeding season (but may plausibly refer to breeding localities) (Shafi *et al.* 2018, Gray *et al.* 2019, Sadi *et al.* 2023, Timmins *et al.* 2024) have all been in lowland forests however. Recent wintering records from the Bangladesh Sundarbans have been from mangrove forest (Sadi *et al.* 2023, eBird 2025). Its diet includes small fish, shrimps and invertebrates, and it appears to be almost entirely nocturnal (Pilgrim *et al.* 2009).

Systems: Terrestrial, Freshwater (=Inland waters)

Use and Trade

This species' cryptic behaviour presumably safeguards it from most exploitation. In Viet Nam, it has been suggested that hunting is the main threat to this species, with evidence from online groups (on Zalo and Facebook 2020-2022) of trade (D. L. Yong *in litt.* 2025). It is unknown whether trade is international.

Threats (see Appendix for additional information)

The main threat to this species overall is habitat loss and degradation, principally driven by timber extraction and expanding agriculture. Recent rates of tree cover loss in China, where the vast majority of this species breeds, are negligible (Global Forest Watch 2025), in large part because of recent reforestation efforts (e.g. Hua *et al.* 2016). Accordingly, any local habitat loss and degradation are

inferred to have a relatively minor impact. This species may be locally hunted and in Viet Nam this may be the main threat, with reports that it is being traded online (D. L. Yong *in litt.* 2025). In Viet Nam, overfishing and the intensive use of agricultural chemicals are reported as being widespread (Pilgrim *et al.* 2009). The impact of chemical pesticides and fertilizers is unknown. Other threats affecting Ba Be National Park, Viet Nam, include firewood collection, harvesting of non-timber forest products, occupation of agricultural land within the park, cattle-grazing, water pollution and sedimentation (Eames and Le Manh Hung 2009, Walsh 2010).

Conservation Actions (see Appendix for additional information)

Conservation Actions Underway

It is a Class II nationally protected species in China. It has been recorded in or near several protected areas in China, including Shennongjia Nature Reserve (Hubei), Tianmu Shan National Nature Reserve (Zhejiang), Dayao Shan Nature Reserve and Daming Shan Nature Reserve (Guangxi), Chebaling National Nature Reserve (Guangdong), Jianfengling Nature Reserve and Wuzhishan Nature Reserve (Hainan), and Jiulianshan Nature Reserve (Jiangxi) (Tang Pei-Rong and Liao Cheng-Kai 2003). In Viet Nam, it has been recorded in Ba Be National Park and Na Hang Nature Reserve (Nguyen Cu 2008, Eames and Le Manh Hung 2009, Pilgrim *et al.* 2009, J. Pilgrim *in litt.* 2009, Walsh 2010). Special nature reserves have been created for the species in Fusui and Shangsi, southern Guangxi (Fellowes *et al.* 2001), of which the former was later merged administratively with the Fusui Precious Animal Reserve protecting the white-headed leaf monkey *Trachypithecus poliocephalus*.

Conservation Actions Proposed

Continue to survey for this species, particularly outside of China where its distribution (and seasonal occurrence) remains poorly known. This will also help inform a more accurate population size.

Credits

Assessor(s):	BirdLife International
Reviewer(s):	Vine, J.
Contributor(s):	Crosby, M., Fellowes, J., Hafner, H., He, F., Kushlan, J., Lau, M., Pilgrim, J. & Yong, D.
Facilitator(s) and Compiler(s):	Benstead, P., Bird, J., Calvert, R., Crosby, M., Harding, M., Peet, N., Taylor, J., Westrip, J.R.S. & Berryman, A.
Partner(s) and Institution(s):	BirdLife International
Authority/Authorities:	IUCN SSC Bird Red List Authority (BirdLife International)

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Appendix

Habitats

(<http://www.iucnredlist.org/technical-documents/classification-schemes>)

Habitat	Season	Suitability	Major Importance?
1. Forest -> 1.6. Forest - Subtropical/Tropical Moist Lowland	Resident	Suitable	Yes
1. Forest -> 1.7. Forest - Subtropical/Tropical Mangrove Vegetation Above High Tide Level	Non-breeding season	Suitable	Yes
5. Wetlands (inland) -> 5.1. Wetlands (inland) - Permanent Rivers/Streams/Creeks (includes waterfalls)	Resident	Suitable	Yes
14. Artificial/Terrestrial -> 14.3. Artificial/Terrestrial - Plantations	Breeding season	Suitable	No
14. Artificial/Terrestrial -> 14.6. Artificial/Terrestrial - Subtropical/Tropical Heavily Degraded Former Forest	Resident	Suitable	No

Use and Trade

(<http://www.iucnredlist.org/technical-documents/classification-schemes>)

End Use	Local	National	International
1. Food - human	Yes	Yes	No

Threats

(<http://www.iucnredlist.org/technical-documents/classification-schemes>)

Threat	Timing	Scope	Severity
2. Agriculture & aquaculture -> 2.1. Annual & perennial non-timber crops -> 2.1.3. Agro-industry farming	Ongoing	Minority (<50%)	Slow, significant declines
Stresses:	1. Ecosystem stresses -> 1.1. Ecosystem conversion 1. Ecosystem stresses -> 1.2. Ecosystem degradation		
2. Agriculture & aquaculture -> 2.3. Livestock farming & ranching -> 2.3.2. Small-holder grazing, ranching or farming	Ongoing	Minority (<50%)	Negligible declines
Stresses:	1. Ecosystem stresses -> 1.2. Ecosystem degradation		
5. Biological resource use -> 5.1. Hunting & trapping terrestrial animals -> 5.1.1. Intentional use (species is the target)	Ongoing	Minority (<50%)	Unknown
Stresses:	2. Species Stresses -> 2.1. Species mortality		
5. Biological resource use -> 5.3. Logging & wood harvesting -> 5.3.3. Unintentional effects: (subsistence/small scale) [harvest]	Ongoing	Minority (<50%)	Slow, significant declines
Stresses:	1. Ecosystem stresses -> 1.1. Ecosystem conversion 1. Ecosystem stresses -> 1.2. Ecosystem degradation		

9. Pollution -> 9.3. Agricultural & forestry effluents -> 9.3.2. Soil erosion, sedimentation	Ongoing	Minority (<50%)	Unknown
Stresses: 1. Ecosystem stresses -> 1.2. Ecosystem degradation			
9. Pollution -> 9.3. Agricultural & forestry effluents -> 9.3.3. Herbicides and pesticides	Ongoing	Minority (<50%)	Unknown
Stresses: 1. Ecosystem stresses -> 1.2. Ecosystem degradation			

Conservation Actions in Place

(<http://www.iucnredlist.org/technical-documents/classification-schemes>)

Conservation Action in Place
In-place research and monitoring
Action Recovery Plan: No
Systematic monitoring scheme: No
In-place land/water protection
Conservation sites identified: Yes, over entire range
Occurs in at least one protected area: Yes
Invasive species control or prevention: No
In-place species management
Successfully reintroduced or introduced benignly: No
Subject to ex-situ conservation: No
In-place education
Subject to recent education and awareness programmes: No
Included in international legislation: No
Subject to any international management / trade controls: No

Research Needed

(<http://www.iucnredlist.org/technical-documents/classification-schemes>)

Research Needed	Notes
1. Research -> 1.2. Population size, distribution & trends	Continue to survey for this species, particularly outside of china where its distribution (and seasonal occurrence) remains poorly known. this will also help inform a more accurate population size.

Additional Data Fields

Distribution
Continuing decline in area of occupancy (AOO): Unknown
Extreme fluctuations in area of occupancy (AOO): No
Estimated extent of occurrence (EOO) (km ²): 2115000
Continuing decline in extent of occurrence (EOO): Unknown
Extreme fluctuations in extent of occurrence (EOO): No
Continuing decline in number of locations: Unknown
Extreme fluctuations in the number of locations: No
Lower elevation limit (m): 0
Upper elevation limit (m): 1,300
Population
Number of mature individuals: 1,500-15,000
Continuing decline of mature individuals: Unknown
Extreme fluctuations: No
Population severely fragmented: No
No. of subpopulations: 1
Continuing decline in subpopulations: Unknown
Extreme fluctuations in subpopulations: No
All individuals in one subpopulation: Yes
No. of individuals in largest subpopulation: 1500-15000
Habitats and Ecology
Continuing decline in area, extent and/or quality of habitat: Yes
Generation Length (years): 5.04
Movement patterns: Full Migrant
Congregatory: Congregatory (and dispersive)

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